A DATA STORY

Inside the Indie Startup Economy

What 1,000 revenue-verified startups on TrustMRR reveal about the tools founders use, who really grows, and where the numbers stop telling the truth.

An analysis of the TrustMRR public dataset · 1,000 startup profiles · frozen 30 Jul 2026

CONTEXT

First, what is TrustMRR?

A public ledger where founders connect real payment data to prove their revenue is real — not a screenshot, not a claim.

1

Connect a read-only key

Founder links Stripe, RevenueCat, Paddle or another provider — no manual entry.

2

Revenue syncs live

MRR, growth and subscriber counts pull automatically, refreshed hourly.

3

A verified profile goes public

The startup gets a leaderboard rank and a shareable proof-of-revenue badge.

4

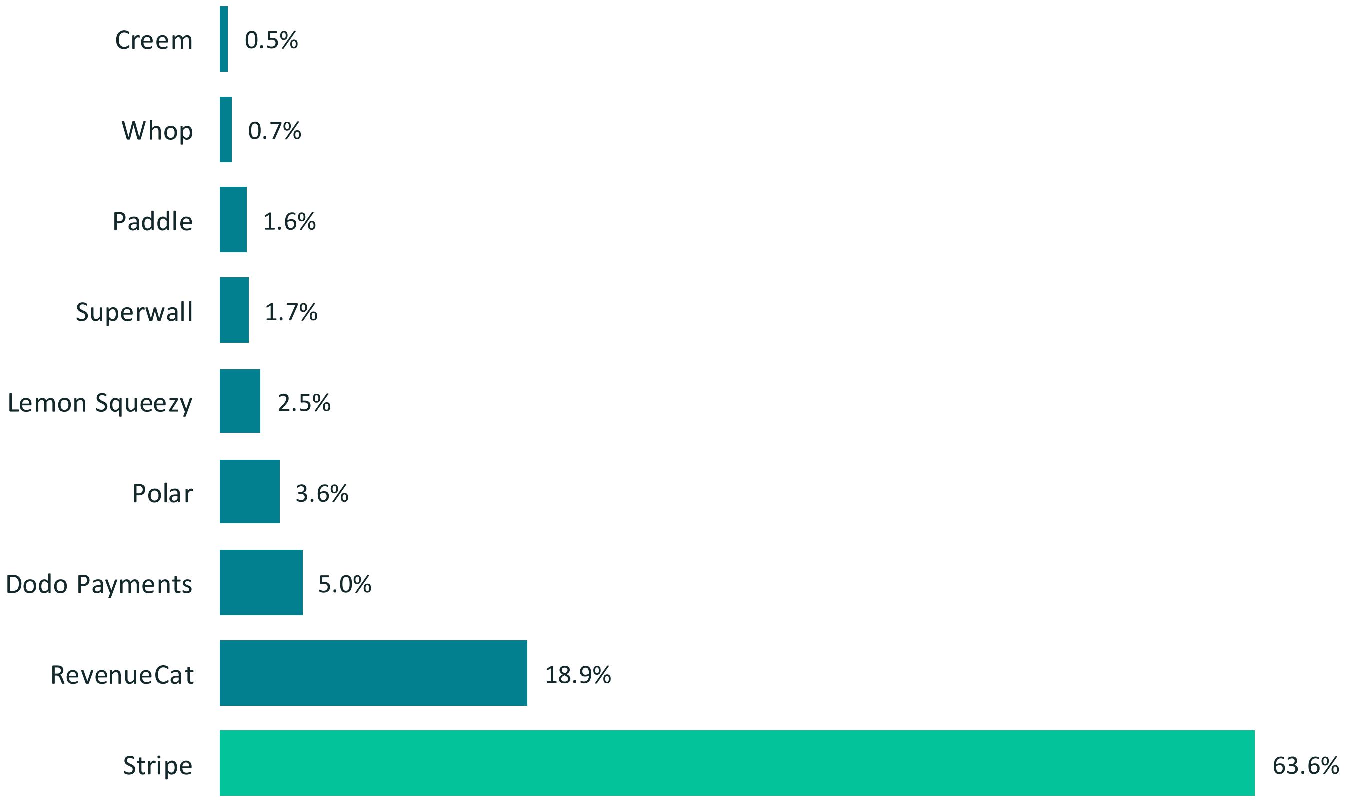
Optionally, it goes up for sale

Founders can list the business with an asking price and revenue multiple.

Every number in this deck comes from that verified layer — 1,000 live startup profiles, frozen for analysis on 30 Jul 2026. Nothing here is self-reported.

The plumbing behind 1,000 startups

Which payment rail a founder plugs into says a lot about who they're actually building for.



1 in 5 startups here monetize through RevenueCat — meaning a huge slice of this “indie SaaS” economy is really mobile apps billing through Apple/Google, not the web.

A new “merchant of record” layer — Lemon Squeezy, Polar, Dodo, Paddle, Creem — exists mainly so solo founders don't have to file VAT/sales-tax themselves. Together they already power ~13% of listings.

Founders on Superwall (specialist paywall tooling) post a median $2,999/mo — 7.5x the platform median — even in a small sample. Monetization tooling, not just payment plumbing, is a tell.

This is a winner-take-most economy

~50%

of all monthly revenue across the 1,000 startups comes from just the top 1% — 10 companies.

~84%

of total revenue is captured by the top 10% of listings.

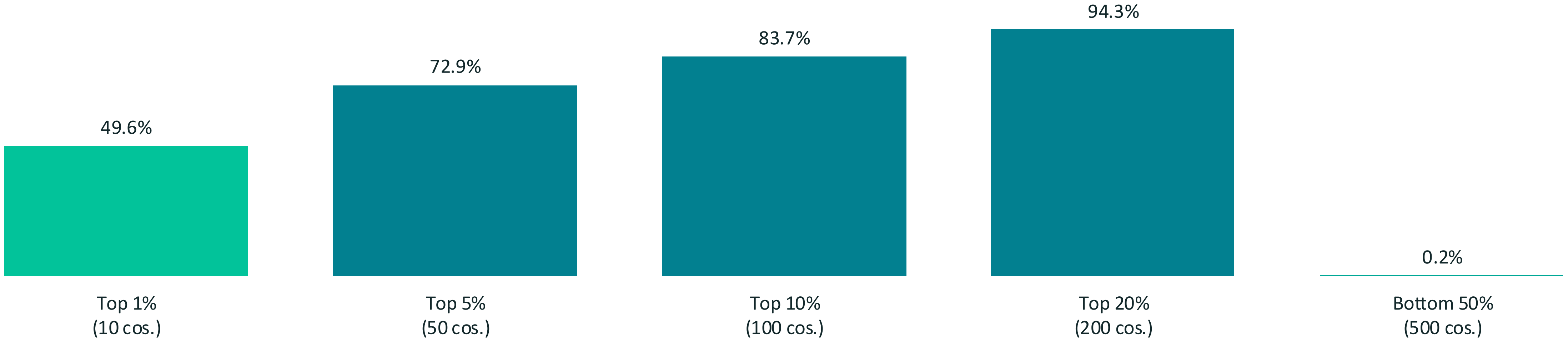
$400

is the median startup's monthly revenue — half of all 1,000 earn less.

39x

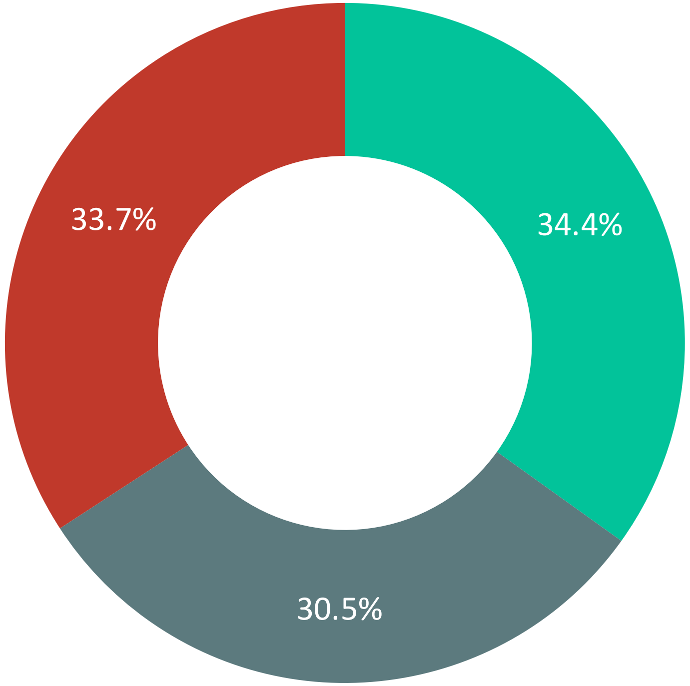
the average ($15.6K/mo) sits above the median — a few outliers (one does $2.8M/mo) skew everything.

Share of total monthly revenue captured, by percentile of startups



Being listed isn't the same as growing

Every startup on this leaderboard has verified revenue. Far fewer are actually growing it.



Growing

344 startups (34.4%) grew revenue in the last 30 days.

Flat

305 startups (30.5%) posted exactly 0% growth — stalled.

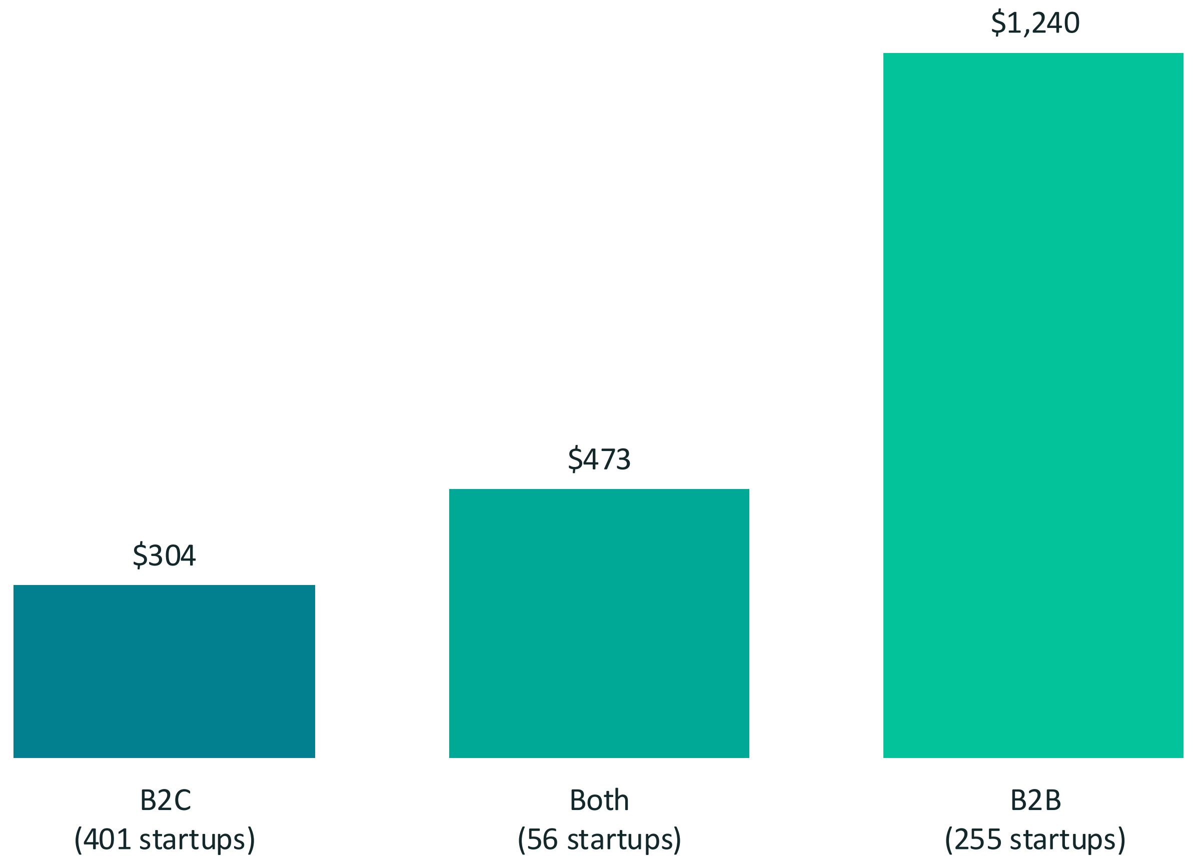
Declining

337 startups (33.7%) made less this month than last.

The badge proves the revenue number is real. It says nothing about which direction it's moving right now.

WHO PAYS BETTER

Selling to businesses pays ≈ 4x better



4.1x

higher median monthly revenue for B2B startups ($1,240) vs. B2C ($304) across this dataset.

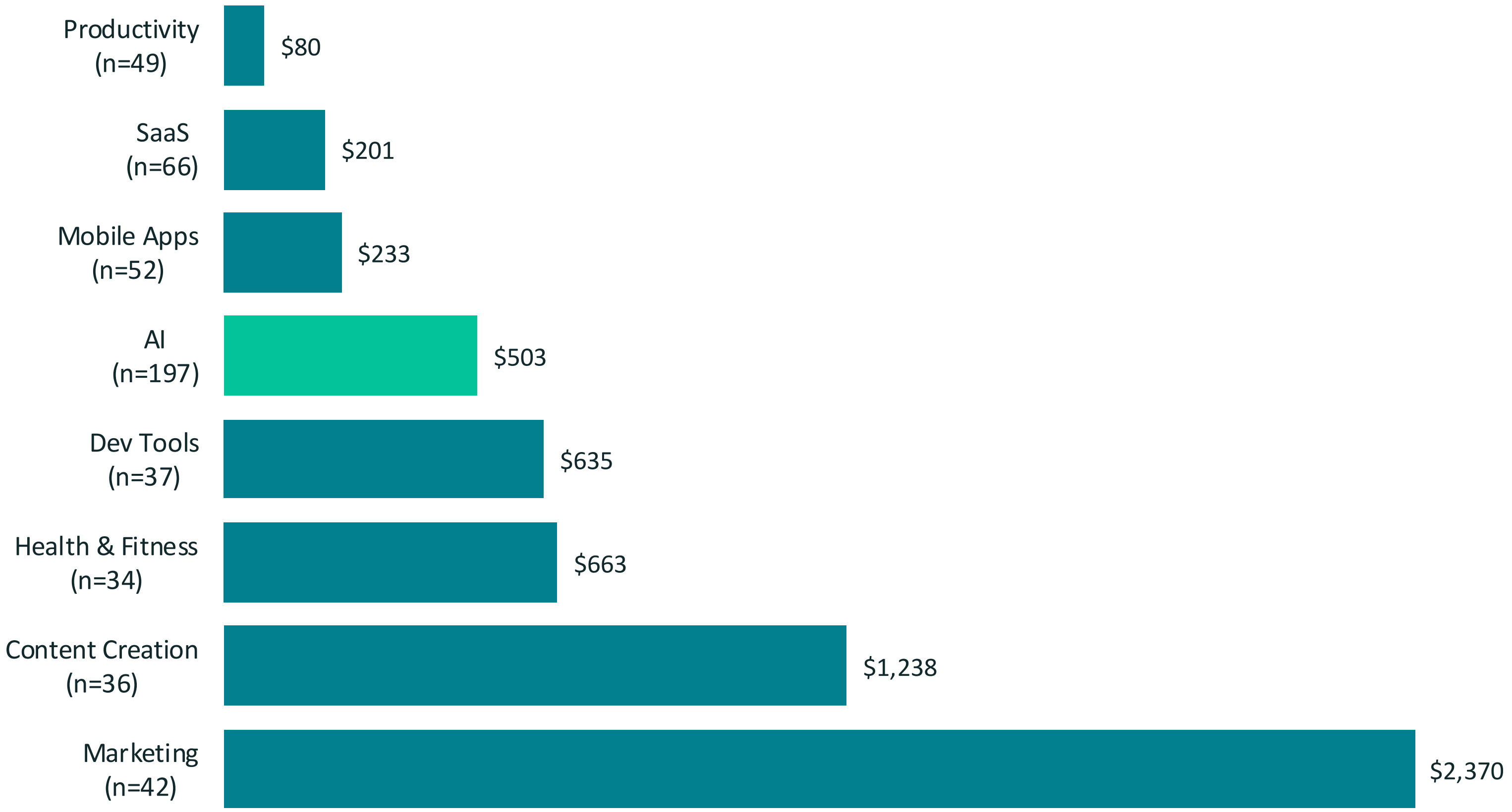
401 vs 255

B2C is the more crowded bet — more founders are chasing consumers than businesses, for a smaller per-company payoff.

CATEGORY ECONOMICS

AI is the most crowded category — and a middling earner

Median monthly revenue by category (top 8 categories by number of startups)



Nearly 1 in 5 startups on TrustMRR call themselves “AI” — more than the next three categories combined. Yet their median monthly revenue trails plainer categories like Marketing and Content Creation. Volume of founders isn't the same as monetization.

Built on transparency. Its biggest winners hide.

129

startups (12.9% of the whole dataset) list themselves only as “Stealth Company” — no public name, website, or domain on record.

$8,362

is their median monthly revenue — roughly 21x the platform-wide median of $400.

100%

of these stealth listings withhold every identifying detail, yet still expose live, verified revenue and MRR.

The founders with the most to protect — real traction, a real moat — are also the most likely to stay anonymous while still proving the number. Verification and identity turn out to be two very different things.

The badge verifies the revenue. Not the price.

262 of the 1,000 startups (26%) are listed for sale, with an asking price and a stated revenue multiple.

1 in 5

on-sale listings (47 of 262) carry a “0.0x” revenue multiple — the asking price isn't anchored to revenue at all.

16 listings

ask real cash — up to $10,000, ~$4,000 typical — for a business with $0 revenue in the trailing 12 months.

3.0x

is the median asking multiple where one is actually calculable — but it ranges as high as 300x+ trailing revenue.

“Revenue-verified” only means the payment API connection is real. It says nothing about whether the price, the multiple, or the business itself makes sense — that diligence is still on the buyer.

SO WHAT

What this actually means if you're building

1

Distribution ≠ revenue

X/Twitter followers barely correlate with monthly revenue ($r \approx 0.02$) across all 1,000 profiles. Build monetization, not just an audience.

2

B2B pays better, on average

Same founder effort, roughly 4x the revenue per company. Consumer apps are more crowded for a smaller payoff.

3

Infra is a tell, not just a tool

Founders using dedicated monetization tooling (Superwall, Whop) sit in visibly higher-revenue cohorts than plain payment API users.

4

Verified ≠ vetted

A live payment connection proves the number. It doesn't prove the price, the multiple, or the business is sound — check the math yourself.

5

Growth is the exception

A third of “featured” startups are shrinking right now. Benchmark your own progress against reality, not the leaderboard.